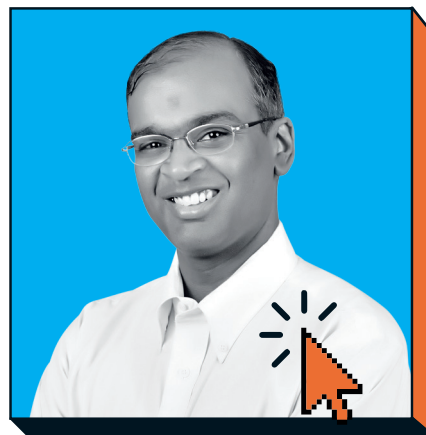


GONE ARE THE DAYS when the HR department had a software system to only manage attendance and payroll. Want someone to take care of online application tracking? Check. Need to outsource video interviewing? Not a problem. Require help with employee engagement during hiring? It can be taken care of. Today, there's a SaaS (software-as-a-service) platform available for almost every conceivable people function—courtesy several start-ups trying to solve for all possible gaps in the hire-to-retire employee journey. "Organisations realise that people make a company. Raw materials or factory assets don't—they are essential, but that's the extent of it," says salary-on-demand start-up Refyne's Co-founder and CTO Apoorv Kumar, calling Covid-19 an inflection point in the journey of HR tech start-ups. Its flagship product of Earned Wage Access allows employees to withdraw from whatever salary they have earned till that date.

"Because of the pandemic, a lot of hiring went online, and there is more acceptance for digital tools. Hence, the adoption for a tool like mine has gone up and I see an increase in revenue," says skill assessment platform DoSelect's Co-founder Rohit Agarwal. The company was acquired by Naukri.com in 2021. Most of these start-ups are in their growth stage and claim manifold increase in their user base. Co-founder and CEO of BetterPlace, Pravin Agarwala, says the blue-collar HRMS (human resource management system) provider used to train 50,000 people through its mobile app two years ago. "Today, we do almost 400,000."

Recruiting firm Careernet's CEO and Co-founder Anshuman Das says Covid-19 showed companies that remote, online hiring could be efficient, cost-saving and done at scale. He gives the example of a leading IT major, which used to hire 18,000-20,000 freshers from 500 campuses over nine months. "In one project that we were working with them, we were able to hire 25,000 from 700 campuses in 25 days," he says. Once that trust was earned, technology started getting built into other HR functions as well, he adds. "Overall cost of hiring goes down because of lack of travel, and companies are spending that money on these platforms."

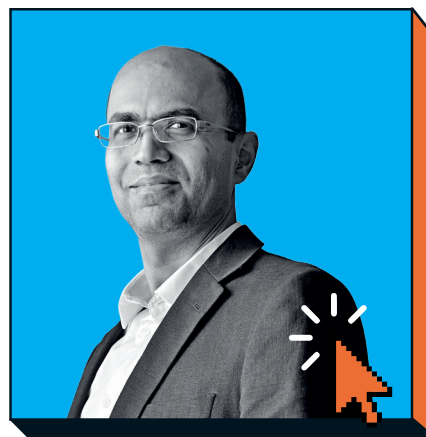
Business analytics platform CB Insights estimates that HR software is projected to become a \$43-billion industry worldwide by 2026. India-specific data was not available, but people in the field say there is a huge opportunity as all organisations use some technology in their HR functions. Enterprise application software firm SAP's Success Factors powers the HR functions of 13,000 customers globally across 25 industries. Sanket Deodhar, SAP Indian Subcontinent's Vice President for Tata group & Unicorns, says, "The maturity of adoption of digitalisation in HR is comparable with other func-



NO TOUCHPOINT IN HR TODAY IS NOT CONNECTED TO TECH... ALL THE WAY FROM ALUMNI PORTALS TO USING THEM TO GET EMPLOYEES BACK INTO THE ORGANISATION

VIJAYSHANKAR ANANTHANARAYAN
VICE PRESIDENT & GLOBAL HEAD OF TRANSFORMATION, DARWINBOX

PHOTO BY MILIND SHELTE



HR TECH START-UPS ARE SEEING SIGNIFICANT ADOPTION BY COMPANIES. WE USED TO HAVE 30,000 SMBs ON OUR PLATFORM A MONTH. IT HAS GONE UP 4X TO 140,000 IN A MATTER OF TWO YEARS

KUNAL PATIL
CEO, WORKINDIA